

The Mad Alchemist

A Learn-to-Play Adventure

One session for seven new players --- for the
Ashen Role-Playing Game

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INTRODUCTION



ADVENTURE SUMMARY

The Mad Alchemist is a **learn-to-play adventure** for the Ashen role-playing game: a single session of three and a half to four hours, designed for a table of new players using the seven pregenerated characters from the player packet. Every scene introduces one part of the system, in play, at the moment the players need it — no rules lecture required.

The structure follows the five-room dungeon model adapted for teaching: an easy skills scene, a fun first fight, a roleplay scene, a showcase of the system's signature mechanic, and a climactic battle. Each scene's chapter opens with the **system lesson** it carries and the **time budget** it should stay inside.

For the Game Master: This adventure assumes you have read the core rulebook, but it does not assume you have run a game before. Where the adventure asks you to make a judgement call, it tells you what factors to weigh. Where it presents a skill check, it tells you what the result means. Trust the structure, and trust your players.

HOW TO USE THIS DOCUMENT

This adventure uses several formatting conventions to help you find information quickly during play:

Text in this style is meant to be read aloud or paraphrased to your players. It sets a scene, describes what the characters see, or delivers an NPC's words. You do not need to read it verbatim — use it as a starting point and make it your own.

Text in this style is a note for you, the Game Master. It provides context, tactical advice, or guidance on how to handle a situation. Your players should not see this information unless you choose to share it.

Text in this style flags something important — a common pitfall, a design intention you should not undermine, or a moment that requires careful handling. Read these before the session.

Skill checks are noted inline as **Skill DN** (e.g. **Occultism D3**), where the number is the difficulty. The result of the check — what information it yields or what happens on success — follows immediately.

ADVENTURE SYNOPSIS

People are disappearing from the outskirts of Keshto Village — foragers, travelers, and now Never-Still peacekeepers sent to investigate. The Never-Still have posted a Black Guard contract, and Merzaghaal, their agent in Keshto, briefs the party (**Scene 0**).

The party follows the trail of the disappearances northeast into the thinning Weald (**Scene 1**) and finds the ravine where the perpetrator dumps his victims: desiccated bodies, emptied of their souls by methodical, scholarly alchemy. The dead do not stay still — reanimated peacekeepers and Fog-drawn beasts attack, led by something that used to be a sergeant of the watch (**Scene 2**).

Evidence in hand, the party returns to Keshto, where Merzaghaal points them to Sennakht, a reclusive ex-Mortefactor. If they can persuade her to talk (**Scene 3**), she names the culprit — Šauhahten, a Mirror expelled from the Most Ancient and Noble Order of Mortefactors for ex-

perimenting on souls — and shares the secret of the old fey shrine he has made his lair beneath: *the door opens only for the dead*.

At the shrine (**Scene 4**), the party pays the threshold's price — a Deathless character must die to open the way, and rises again by the grace of the Essence that makes the Deathless what they are. Below, in a laboratory of glass and stolen souls (**Scene 5**), they confront Šauhahten himself: calm, articulate, and utterly certain that his murders are necessary to heal the world. He fights beside his Chimera and his homunculi until his work is lost — then vanishes through a silvered mirror, beaten but not finished.

The contract is fulfilled. The victims are avenged. And somewhere in the Fog, the Mad Alchemist begins again (**Epilogue**).

THE FIVE ROOMS

Each scene teaches one thing. Introduce rules only when the scene needs them; the character profiles in the player packet carry the rest.

SCENES AND SYSTEM LESSONS

Scene	What Happens	What It Teaches
0	Merzaghhaal's briefing	Who the characters are; how to talk to an NPC
1	Investigation and tracking	Skill checks, group checks, preparation paying off
2	Fight at the dump site	Initiative, AP, attacks, conditions, terrain
3	Persuading the recluse	Social play; more than one approach works
4	The threshold sacrifice	Death, spot-revival, and Essence Points — the signature mechanic, demonstrated safely
5	Šauhahten's laboratory	Powers and FP under pressure; objectives beyond "kill everything"

PACING FOR SEVEN PLAYERS

The session budget below totals about 3 hours 40 minutes plus a break. The two combats are

the immovable objects; everything else flexes around them.

SESSION CLOCK

Scene	Budget	Clock (elapsed)
Scene 0 — The Briefing	15 min	0:15
Scene 1 — The Investigation	30 min	0:45
Scene 2 — Fight at the Dump Site	65 min	1:50
Break	10 min	2:00
Scene 3 — The Recluse	25 min	2:25
Scene 4 — The Threshold	15 min	2:40
Scene 5 — The Laboratory	65 min	3:45
Epilogue	10 min	3:55

Checkpoints and cuts. If you are not rolling initiative at the dump site by the one-hour mark, stop calling for checks and hand the party the trail. If Scene 2 runs long, compress Scene 3: Sennakht names her price immediately (the journals) and one good roll seals the deal. If you reach Scene 5 with less than an hour left, drop two homunculi and trigger The Vanishing the moment Šauhahten drops below half HP.

Speeding up seven-player combat:

- Enemies act in groups: all husks on one initiative count, both beasts on another, named creatures on their own.
- Ask each player to plan their turn while the previous one resolves. Every character profile ends with a scripted opening move — point new players at it.
- Minions die to almost any hit. Do not track their HP precisely; track how many are left.
- Call the round order out loud so people know when they are "on deck."

THE CHARACTERS

The adventure assumes the seven pregenerated characters from the player packet. Each of them has a personal stake in this contract, and each has a scene where their sheet gets to shine.

Character	Stake	Spotlight Moments
Ushtëng	Vazhan, a vanished peacekeeper, was his friend	Scene 2: faces what Vazhan has become
Zamazaha	A free agent, here for the contract	Scenes 2 & 5: duels the revenant and the Chimera
Pâhâk	Vague Perfector orders about the disappearances	Scene 4: Electroception senses the machinery below; covering fire everywhere
Kalariyar	The fey sites might hold their lost memories	Scene 1: best tracker; Scene 3: Sennakht knows what a Shade is; Scene 4: the door “remembers” them
Wishanya	Wants the practitioner’s notes	Scene 2: reads the alchemy; Scene 5: fire stops the Chimera’s regeneration
Kho Prea	Sent because the Clear is thinning	Scene 1: investigation; Scene 4: understands the ritual; healing in both fights
Mbazân	Lost patrols are his business	Scenes 0, 1 & 3: the party’s voice; command powers in both fights

Table 1: Spotlight Map

If a character is not in play, their spotlight beats simply go unused — nothing breaks.

NPC QUICK REFERENCE

NPCS

Name	Race	Faction	Role
Merzaghaal	Golden-bristle	Never-Still	Quest-giver, faction contact
Reeve Otta-van	Human	—	Local authority, disappearance records
Dashek	Human	Never-Still	Surviving peacekeeper, points to the field
Vazhan	Human (dead)	Never-Still	Ushtëng’s friend; rises as the Hollow Revenant
Sennakht	Human (Deathless)	Mortefactors (retired)	Recluse; knows Šauhahten and the fey door
Šauhahten	Mirror	Ex-Mortefactors	Villain

XP AND WEALTH

A single-session award, tallied at the end. With the mission bonus and loot, each character finishes with roughly 350 XP toward their next advances — a concrete “here is what playing on looks like” hook.

EXPECTED XP PER CHARACTER

Source	XP
Scene 2 combat (husks, beasts, revenant)	102
Scene 5 combat (Šauhahten, Chimera, homunculi)	118
Mission XP (fulfil the contract)	100
Loot XP (estimated)	30–60
Total	350–380

The Black Guard contract pays **700 f** to the party on completion, plus whatever they salvage from the laboratory (see the Loot Table in the Appendix).

SCENE 0: THE BRIEFING



Time budget: 15 minutes. Lesson: who the characters are, and how talking to an NPC works.

The adventure begins in Keshto Village, a frontier settlement in the Venna Weald clear, at the village's only inn, where Merzaghaal has gathered everyone who answered the contract.

Keshto is small and practical — a cluster of stone and timber buildings around a market square, ringed by a low wall that marks the boundary between settlement and wilderness. The Weald presses close on all sides, ancient forest visible over the rooftops. The air smells of woodsmoke and rain.

Before the briefing: go around the table and have each player introduce their character in a sentence or two — name, what they look like, why they answered the contract (each profile's "Who You Are" section answers this). With seven players this is the cheapest way to make the table feel like a party, and it hands you their hooks to call back to later. Keep it brisk: one minute each.

MERZAGHAAL'S BRIEFING

The Goldenbristle leans forward across the table, his bristled mane catching the lamplight. He speaks carefully, as if weighing each word against the cost of saying it.

"Thank you for coming. I will be direct. Over the past three months, eleven people have gone missing from the outskirts of this settlement. Six civilians — foragers, a trapper, a courier. Five of our peacekeepers, sent to investigate. None have returned. No bodies have been recovered.

"The disappearances cluster along the north-eastern routes, where the Weald thins and the

Fog gets thicker. They are accelerating — three in the last two weeks alone.

"Your job is to find out what is taking these people and put a stop to it. Speak to Reeve Otta-
van — she keeps the records. Speak to Dashek — he is the only one who came back. And then follow whatever you find. Payment on completion: seven hundred feathers."

Merzaghaal

- **Race:** Goldenbristle (Sootbeast)
- **Faction:** Never-Still (mid-level agent)
- **Personality:** Competent, professional, dry. Cares about this as a faction matter first, a humanitarian crisis second. Not callous — simply prioritised. He will be frustrated if the party wastes time.
- **What he knows:** The timeline and geography of the disappearances. That the peacekeepers who were sent were competent and should not have simply vanished. That there is an old fey shrine northeast of Keshto the Never-Still consider significant — though he has no reason yet to connect it to the case.
- **What he can provide:** Introductions to the reeve and to Dashek, access to Never-Still records and supplies, and a sounding board when the party returns with new information.

Merzaghaal is the party's anchor NPC. He does not go into the field, but he is always available in Keshto to discuss findings and broker introductions. If the party is ever stuck, he can suggest the next step — but he should not solve their problems for them.

If Mbazân is in play, Merzaghaal knows him by reputation — a fellow Goldenbristle officer of the Never-Still — and addresses him as a colleague. Let that player field the briefing questions.

SCENE 1: THE INVESTIGATION



Time budget: 30 minutes. Lesson: skill checks — when to roll, what a difficulty means, and how preparation pays off later.

The party works the village for leads, then follows them into the field. Two conversations and a short tracking challenge take them to the dump site. That is the whole scene; resist the urge to let it sprawl.

Teaching skill checks: call for a roll only when the outcome is uncertain and failure has a consequence. If a player asks the reeve for the disappearance timeline and the reeve has no reason to hide it, just give it to them — no roll. The checks below exist to reward digging deeper, not to gate the plot. Nothing in this scene can dead-end the adventure: the minimum the party needs (a direction to search) is given freely by Dashek.

With seven players, spread the rolls around. If one player has rolled twice and another not at all, ask the quiet one what their character is doing.

LEAD 1: REEVE OTTAVAN

The reeve keeps the village records in a cramped office smelling of tallow and ink. She is harried, worried, and practical — she has been fielding panicked families and shrinking search parties for weeks, and there is an edge of resentment that it took dead *peacekeepers* to get faction attention.

- **What she provides freely:** the list of the missing — names, dates, occupations, last known locations.

DISAPPEARANCES

Name	Occupation	Weeks Ago	Last Seen
Orin Vasek	Forager	11	Northeast trail, past the creek
Dara Millen	Trapper	9	Her trapline, northeast ridge
Josen Haal	Courier	8	Road to Ashmark, northeast fork
Three civilians	Various	6–4	Northeast outskirts
Vazhan & Dashek	Patrol	3	Northeast, investigating Vasek route
Three peacekeepers	Search party	2	Northeast, broader search
Pel Torren	Forager	1	Northeast, near the old shrine trail

• Skill checks:

- **Investigate D2:** Build the timeline. The pattern is stark: every victim was alone or in a small group, every disappearance is in the northeast, and the frequency is increasing. Whatever is doing this is getting hungrier — or bolder.
- **Influence D3:** The reeve opens up about the toll on the community. People are afraid to leave the walls; the forager economy is collapsing. She is grateful someone is finally taking this seriously. (Mbazân's lane — Influence 7.)

LEAD 2: DASHEK, THE SURVIVOR

Dashek was half of the first patrol sent out — the other half was Sergeant Vazhan. Dashek did not see what happened: one moment Vazhan was there, the next he was not. Dashek found signs of a brief struggle and no body, searched until dark, and has not slept properly since.

- **What he provides without a check:** the place where Vazhan vanished — a fold of foothills northeast of the village, where the Weald thins and the Fog draws close. This is the party's starting point. **Do not make the party roll for this.**
- **Skill checks:**
 - **Influence D2:** Get him talking properly. He wants to help but is drowning in guilt; a sympathetic approach works better than a demanding one. He describes the terrain in useful detail — landmarks, the creek crossing, the game trails (this earns the **preparation bonus** in the tracking challenge below).
 - **Awareness D3:** Notice what he is not saying: Vazhan was his sergeant and his friend, and Dashek ran when the silence got too loud. He has been telling himself he searched thoroughly. He did not.

If Ushtâng is in play: Vazhan was Ushtâng's friend too — that is why Ushtâng is here. Let the two of them have a beat. Dashek can tell Ushtâng what the official reports would not: Vazhan's halberd was gone with him, and there was no blood. Ushtâng's player now has a name to carry into Scene 2 — do not foreshadow further.

OPTIONAL LEAD: IBBEH'S CUSTOMER

If the party asks around the market about strangers or unusual purchases (**Investigate D3** to find the right person), they are pointed to Ibbah, a dry-goods trader with a long memory.

She remembers a remarkable customer from about half a year ago: tall, Mirror features — the fey shimmer of an Echo — polite, spoke in measured sentences. Bought in bulk: glassware, reagents, heavy sealed containers. Asked odd questions about the local Fog. Always left northeast. Stopped coming perhaps six months ago.

This is colour now and confirmation later — Sennakht will put a name to the description in Scene 3. If the party skips this lead, nothing is lost. If time is short, cut it.

INTO THE FIELD: THE TRACKING CHALLENGE

Dashek's directions give the party the right *area*, not the right *location*. The journey northeast takes half a day on foot; the last stretch is a search.

The forest changes as you move northeast. The canopy thins. The underbrush grows sparser but stranger — pale shoots, fungi that should not grow this far from the Fog. The birdsong stops before you notice it has stopped. The air takes on a faint chemical tang that does not belong to any forest.

The party makes a short series of group checks to find the ravine. Each stretch represents a section of the Weald that must be searched or reasoned through.

Number of stretches: Start with 2. Each failed check adds 1 stretch (to a maximum of 3 total). Each success clears 1.

Available checks (each stretch, the party picks an approach and a lead roller; others may assist):

- **Awareness D3:** Read the terrain — broken branches at a consistent height, undergrowth trampled in a line, pale fungi clustering along disturbed soil. Something has passed this way many times. (Kalariyar's lane — Awareness 7.)
- **Investigate D3:** Reason out the disposal logic. Whoever is behind this needs somewhere screened from observation, far from Keshto, near the Fog boundary. That narrows the search to ravines and depressions in one corridor of the Weald.
- **Stamina D4:** Brute persistence — push through rough terrain and Fog-headache to walk the grid when cleverness fails.

Preparation bonus: If the party got Dashek's detailed directions (the Influence D2 above), reduce all DCs by 1. Say so out loud — this is the lesson: *talking to people before you leave makes the wilderness easier.*

Complications on failure (pick one per failed stretch):

- A wrong drainage channel costs an hour; the party will reach the ravine at dusk. (This

is atmospheric, not punitive — and kind to Kalariyar, whose Shade eyes dislike daylight.)

- A loose scree slope: the character who led the check makes an **Athletics D3** or takes 3 damage and arrives at the bottom Prone.
- The party crosses a Fog-Touched Beast's hunting ground. In Scene 2, the beasts are present from round 1 instead of arriving on round 2.

Pacing: 5–10 minutes of real time. Describe each stretch briefly — a fork in the terrain, a moment of doubt — call for the check, narrate the result, and move on. Two successes and they are there.

SCENE 2: THE DUMP SITE



Time budget: 65 minutes, most of it combat.
Lesson: initiative, AP, attacks and damage, conditions, and terrain.

The ravine is where Šauhahten disposes of his victims after extracting their souls; the shallow cave at its head is where the extractions happen. Both the evidence and the fight live here — the party gets the full horror of the operation in a single location.

THE SCENE

The ravine lies in a fold of the Weald's foothills where a seasonal stream has cut a channel through soft stone. It runs roughly northeast-to-southwest, forty feet long and twenty feet across at its widest, narrowing at both ends. The walls are uneven — fifteen feet sheer on the north side, sloping to eight feet of rough grade on the south. At the ravine's head, a low cave mouth is screened by brush that has been cut and replaced many times.

You smell it before you see it. Not rot, exactly — something drier, more clinical. The trail leads to a shallow ravine screened by deadfall and brush. Someone has piled cut branches over the opening. It is not a natural formation.

Beneath the screen, you find the bodies.

There are ten of them, laid out in a rough row along the west wall, partially covered by a weathered tarp weighed down with stones. They are not decomposed — they are *desiccated*, as if every drop of vitality has been wrung from them. Their skin is paper-thin, stretched tight over bone. Their eyes are open, and their expressions are not peaceful. They look as though something was pulled from them, and they felt every moment of it.

Six of them wear the colors of Never-Still peacekeepers.

Terrain Features

The following features matter in the fight. Sketch the ravine before the session; with seven players you want the map ready, not improvised.

- **Deadfall screen (southwest entry):** Cut branches piled over the ravine's opening, where the trail from Keshto arrives. Cover; blocks line of sight from outside. Moving through costs 1 extra square. 1 AP pulls the screen aside.
- **East slope game trail:** A narrow switchback down the east wall — the route the beasts use. A creature on it has elevation over the floor (advantage on ranged attacks downward, disadvantage on melee from below). Only one Medium creature per section.
- **Drainage channel:** A muddy channel down the ravine floor. Difficult terrain. A character knocked Prone in it is also Slowed (save ends).
- **Rocky outcrops (north ridgeline):** Full cover and a vantage point. Climbing up costs 2 squares of movement, or 1 with an **Athletics D2**. (Pâhâk's gatling wants to be here.)
- **Body row (west wall):** Difficult terrain — uneven ground, loose stones, the tarp itself. The husks rise from here.
- **The cave (northeast head):** The extraction site (see below). During the fight it is simply a dark mouth in the rock; Vazhan rises just outside it.

COMBAT: THE RISEN WATCH

Not all the bodies are still. The Fog boundary's proximity and the residue of imperfect soul extraction have gotten into the older corpses. Šauhahten does not know they have risen, and would not care if he did.

Trigger: the husks animate when the party approaches the body row or begins examining the corpses. If the party is standing near the

row, the husks rise within melee reach — this is deliberate; the moment should be shocking. An **Awareness D3** before that notices the tarp moving: characters who succeed are not surprised in the first round.

Encounter composition (7 characters):

- **6 Soulless Husks** — the reanimated peacekeepers, rising from the row
 - **2 Fog-Touched Beasts** — arriving at the top of the game trail at the start of round 2 (or present from round 1, crouched in the north-slope brush, if the party blundered through their hunting ground in Scene 1)
 - **Vazhan, Hollow Revenant** — rising at the cave mouth at the start of round 2
- Stat blocks are in the Appendix.

(At the start of round 2:)

Something else is standing at the cave mouth. It did not shamble up like the others — it is simply *there*, a halberd in its hands, held in perfect drill-ground guard. It wears a sergeant's sash.

When it opens its mouth, a dozen voices come out at once, and none of them are its own.

Vazhan. Šauhahten's extraction failed part-way on the sergeant — a fragment of soul stayed in the body, and the Fog wove the spilled residue of the other victims around it. What rose is faster, stronger, and far angrier than a husk, and it has power the others do not.

If Ushtëng is in play, this is his scene. Vazhan's face is still recognisable. The **What Remains** ability on the stat block gives Ushtëng (or anyone who invokes Vazhan's name) a way to reach whatever is left — use it to put roleplay *inside* the fight, not after it. When Vazhan is finally destroyed, the fragment of him comes loose: for a heartbeat the voice is singular, and it says Ushtëng's name, and then it is gone. That is the closure the contract cannot pay for.

Running the fight (7 players):

- The husks share one initiative count, the beasts another, Vazhan his own. Three enemy turns per round, no more.
- The husks are mindless: nearest living creature, Slam, attempt to Grab. They do not coordinate or retreat. Let new players learn the rhythm of attack rolls against things that die in one or two hits.
- The beasts are predators, not tacticians: Pounce from the game trail onto whoever is isolated or Grabbed. A beast below half HP flees up the trail and into the Weald.
- Vazhan alternates: Wail of the Taken when two or more characters are within its Burst 2, otherwise Halberd against the biggest threat in reach, Grasp of Residue against ranged attackers he cannot reach. He fights like the sergeant he was — he holds the cave mouth and does not chase.
- **Terrain matters, say so:** Grabbed in the channel means Slowed too; the ridgeline rewards climbers; the game trail funnels the beasts.

Dial: if the party is cruising, the Wail is available every round; if they are struggling, Vazhan spends a round “remembering” after any character invokes his name.

XP: 6 Husks (42) + 2 Beasts (30) + Vazhan (30) = **102.**

Narrative beat: the party is fighting the people they were sent to find. The missing peacekeepers from the reeve's list are the husks wearing watch colors. Let the moment land before initiative — and let the fight be fun anyway. Grief and glee coexist at RPG tables; that is normal.

AFTER THE FIGHT: THE CAVE

The cave at the ravine's head is where the extractions happen — a rough chamber perhaps fifteen feet across, floor swept clean.

Concentric circles have been carved into the stone floor, filled with a residue that catches the

light — pale, faintly luminescent. At the centre, iron stakes have been driven into the rock, fitted with restraints. There are old stains on the restraints that do not need explanation.

Along the walls, crude shelves hold alchemical apparatus: glass vessels, copper tubing, a distillation rig too heavy to move easily. Some vessels still hold a pale, oily substance that seems to move when you are not looking directly at it. The Fog curls into the cave and pools around the circles, as if drawn to them.

This place has been used many times.

Investigating the Scene

Give every player a chance to poke at something. The checks below reward different sheets; none of them gates progress.

- **Occultism D3:** The bodies and the circles agree: souls have been *extracted* — not killed out of, but drawn out of, these people, by deliberate means. This is not a predator and not a natural Fog phenomenon. Someone did this with knowledge and intention.
- **Medicine D4 or Alchemy D4:** No wounds, no poison, no disease. The desiccation is a side effect: the body collapses inward once the animating principle is removed. Clean, almost surgical, performed many times. (Wishanya reads this fluently — “methodical means a practitioner,” exactly as she suspected.)
- **Investigate D3:** The site has been used for months. The scoring shows layered circles, each slightly refined from the last — the perpetrator is *iterating*. The volume matches the missing list. Single set of footprints, coming and going, southwest each time.
- **Ritual D3 or Occultism D4:** This is not necromancy. Necromancy manipulates the boundary between life and death; this treats the soul as a *substance to be distilled*. Scholarly, disciplined — the work of a trained order, not a hedge-cultist. (Kho Prea’s Ritual 6 shines.)

Found without a check, tucked behind the distillation rig: a discarded notebook page in a precise scholarly hand — calculations, a sketch of a circle revision, and a sour marginal note: “*The Order’s foundations were correct. Their courage failed, not their theory.*”

The notebook page is the safety net: whatever the party rolls, they leave this scene knowing the method is the work of a scholarly order — which is the thread Merzaghaal pulls on when they return. The checks above add texture and let specialists feel specialised; the page guarantees the plot.

What the party should know leaving this scene: souls are being extracted by methodical, scholarly alchemy; the perpetrator was not here and does not live here; the trail of evidence points back to a learned order. Time to go home and ask better questions.

SCENE 3: THE RECLUSE



Time budget: 25 minutes. Lesson: social play — more than one approach works, and who does the talking matters.

The party returns to Keshto with evidence of methodical, scholarly soul extraction. Merza-ghaal hears them out, and his face gets progressively harder to read.

“Soul-work with laboratory discipline,” Merza-ghaal says slowly. “There is exactly one order that studies souls the way a gearsmith studies a mechanism, and its members do not take frontier holidays. But one of them lives here. Retired, she says. Sennakht. Keeps a hut past the tannery and speaks to nobody.

“She has refused every request the Never-Still has ever made of her. Perhaps you will have better luck. Do not lie to her — I am told she was a Lector of the Mortefactors for two hundred years, and I doubt she has forgotten how to read people.”

SENNAKHT

- **Race:** Human (Deathless — she has looked sixty for a very long time)
- **Faction:** The Most Ancient and Noble Order of Mortefactors, formally retired
- **Personality:** Dry, precise, entirely unimpressed by weapons, ranks, or Black Guard contracts. She lives alone with her books, her preserved specimens, and a kettle that is always just off the boil. She does not want visitors. She especially does not want *these* visitors, because she has already guessed why they have come.

Her secret, and why she resists: Sennakht knows exactly who the culprit is. Šauhahten was her student, decades ago, before the Order expelled him for advocating soul experimentation — and she is the one who taught him the foundations he built his heresy on. She retired out here, in part, to keep a quiet eye on the region’s fey sites, and she has suspected for months that the disappearances were his work. She said nothing, because saying something meant admitting whose hands had shaped his.

She is not an obstacle because she is hostile. She is an obstacle because she is ashamed.

The hut past the tannery is small, scrupulously clean, and smells of paper and formaldehyde. Shelves line every wall: jars, bones, folios in a dozen dead scripts. The woman who opens the door looks the party up and down once, sighs like a scholar interrupted mid-sentence, and says: “You found the bodies, then. You had better come in before you say anything else where the neighbours can hear.”

THE NEGOTIATION

Sennakht will confirm what the party already knows almost immediately — the technique is Mortefactor-derived, and no, the Order did not sanction it. What she will *not* volunteer is the rest: the name, the place, and the way in. Getting those three things out of her is the scene.

Run it as conversation, not as a dice gauntlet. Let players try approaches in character, call for a check when an approach is genuinely uncertain, and count roughly **two solid successes** (or one success plus one honest, un-rolled human moment) as enough to open her up. Failures do

not end the scene — they cost time and make her pricklier.

Approaches that work:

- **Influence D3 — appeal to the victims.** Names help: Vazhan, Pel Torren, the row of bodies in watch colors. She has spent months not looking at this directly; make her look. (Mbazân's lane, Influence 7.)
- **Show the evidence — no roll.** The notebook page from the cave. She reads the marginal note — *"Their courage failed, not their theory"* — and her hands are not quite steady when she puts it down. She recognises the hand. This counts as a success, automatically.
- **Occultism D3 — speak her language.** Demonstrate that the party actually understood what they saw: distillation of the animating principle, iterated circle revisions. She stops treating them like hired blades and starts treating them like colleagues.
- **Offer her the journals — no roll, but a promise.** If the party offers to bring her Šauhahten's research journals — so the Order's stolen work does not end up in worse hands, or simply so she can see how far he went — she accepts on the spot. Whether they keep that promise in Scene 5 is up to them, and she will remember either way.
- **Impose D4 — lean on her.** It works; she is old, alone, and practical. It also closes her like a book. She gives them the name, the place, and the price, in six flat sentences, and tells them never to come back. No tea, no warnings, no goodwill — and she omits the advice about the door opening freely from the inside, which will cost the party a bad moment in Scene 5.

If Kalariyar is in play: Sennakht falters mid-sentence the first time she looks at them properly.

"A Shade. Here, of all — " She catches herself, and for the first time her courtesy is not ironic. "The old sites will know you, night-child, even if you do not know them. Doors open differently for the Princess's hunters. Sit down. All of you, sit down."

This is Kalariyar's hook paying off — the fey sites really do remember Shades. Mechanically it functions as one automatic success in the negotiation. Narratively it seeds Scene 4: Kalariyar feels the shrine recognise them, whether or not they volunteer for the threshold.

WHAT SHE KNOWS

Once the party has her, deliver all of it — this is the adventure's central exposition, so give it room to breathe.

"His name is Šauhahten. A Mirror. My student, once — the best I ever had, which is precisely the problem. The Order expelled him for arguing, in an open lecture, that souls could be rendered like fat. Prima Materia — the seed-substance of alchemy. He believes it can restart the cycle of death and rebirth. He believes he is *healing the world*. Every corpse in your ravine is, to him, a regrettable line item.

"You will find him beneath the old fey shrine, northeast, past your ravine — where the resonance never faded. It never faded because it is not a ruin. It is a door, and it is sealed the way the Deep Court sealed all their doors.

"The way is shut to the living. That is not a riddle — it is the mechanism. The threshold opens for a death, freely given, inside its circle. A mortal who pays that price is simply gone. One of you —" she looks around the room, unhurried, counting the Deathless, "— will die today, and get back up, and I suggest you decide which of you it will be before you are standing in front of the stones arguing.

"He pays it too, you understand. Every time he goes home, he dies at his own door. He has done it dozens of times by now. Consider what that does to a person, and then stop expecting him to bargain like one."

- **The name and the man:** Šauhahten, Mirror, expelled Mortefactor, brilliant, certain, decades into his obsession. He is Deathless — killing him is a setback for him, not an ending.

- **The place:** the old fey shrine northeast of Keshto, past the ravine. The laboratory is beneath it.
- **The way in:** a Deathless must die inside the threshold circle. The door takes the death; Essence takes them back. (She explains spot-revival in plain words if asked — she has done it herself, and her contempt for the squeamish is gentle but total.)
- **Freely offered, unless she was Imposed upon:** the seal is one-way. From inside, the door opens for anyone. And: “Burn the laboratory. Not the man — the *work*. The man will come back regardless. The work is what matters.”

Keeping it to 25 minutes: Sennakht wants, deep down, to be convinced — do not make the players grind for it. If the clock is against you, she names her price immediately (the journals) and one success closes the deal.

If the party never visits her at all — possible, if they storm off — Merzaghaal extracts the same information through faction channels overnight, minus the door’s secret, and the party learns about the threshold the hard way: standing in front of sealed stones with Kalariyar’s skin prickling. The adventure survives; the scene is just poorer for it.

THE SANCTUM



SCENE 4: THE THRESHOLD

Time budget: 15 minutes. Lesson: death, spot-revival, and Essence Points — the system's signature mechanic, demonstrated where nothing else is trying to kill anyone.

The old fey shrine stands in a clearing in the deep Weald: standing stones overgrown with moss and creeping vine, humming with a resonance felt in the teeth rather than heard.

The standing stones are not a ruin. You can see it now, knowing what to look for: the moss traces lines that were carved long before the moss grew, and the resonance in the air is not faded power — it is *contained* power, held in check by the structure itself. At the centre of the stones, a circle of pale slabs is set flush with the earth, clean of moss, as if the ground itself refuses to grow over it.

Something under your feet is very faintly vibrating.

- **Pâhâk (no roll):** Electroception picks up powered machinery below — a steady electromagnetic murmur of magitek and moving fluid, perhaps forty feet down. Whatever is under this shrine is *running*. (This is also the moment Pâhâk's vague Perfector orders start making sense: someone is operating pre-fall apparatus out here.)
- **Kalariyar (no roll):** The stones know them. The resonance leans toward the Shade like a plant toward light. If Kalariyar steps into the circle, the vibration deepens — welcome, or appetite.
- **Occultism D2:** The inscription spiralling the circle's rim confirms Sennakht's words: *The way is shut to the living. Give the door your death.*

When a Deathless character stands inside the circle and offers themselves — a deliberate act, spoken or willed — the threshold takes its payment.

The hum rises through your bones and becomes a grip. It is not violent and it is not cruel; it is a door asking, one final time, whether you mean it.

Then it takes your death, all at once, the way dark takes a room when the lamp goes out.

Mechanically: the volunteer dies — reduced to 0 HP, no roll, no resistance. The circle of slabs sinks and grinds aside, revealing a stairway descending into worked pale stone. Then run death and spot-revival **exactly by the book:**

1. The character is dead. Their body lies in the circle.
2. At the start of their next turn (out of combat, simply “a few breaths later”), they may spend **5 EP** to revive — returning at **full HP**, standing where they fell.
3. If they choose not to, or cannot, their essence departs for their soul anchor and reincorporates over days — which, in a one-shot, means the character is out of the story. Nobody should choose this; make sure they understand the 5 EP option first.

PAYING THE PRICE

This is the teaching moment the adventure is built around. Take five minutes and do it properly:

- Before anyone volunteers, have the players check their EP (every pregen has 11). Spell out the trade: 5 EP buys you back from death, here and in the fight to come.
- The revival is **full HP**. A character who limped out of Scene 2 wounded gets a complete heal out of volunteering — canny players should be allowed to notice this, and it is a fine piece of system mastery to reward.
- Let the table feel the wrongness anyway. The volunteer dies. Mortals who watched it never quite forget it. Describe the death honestly and the revival gloriously — a mangled stillness, then the body knitting itself back upright, ready for vengeance.
- Connect it forward: “That resource you just spent? That is also your safety net downstairs.” Now the stakes of the finale are legible.

Who volunteers is a roleplay scene, not a die roll — let them argue. If the party stalls: Kalariyar feels the door waiting for them specifically; Ushtëng has the most EP-per-sentiment reasons (“Vazhan paid more”); a badly wounded character has the pragmatic angle. And Sennakht’s parting advice hangs over all of it: Šauhahten has paid this price *dozens of times*.

Rules corner cases, so you are not caught flat: the death is a cost willingly paid, not an attack — no resistance applies, and effects that trigger “when hit” do not trigger. Kho Prea’s Gift of the Sun cannot buy the door off; there is no check to add successes to. The door does not damage the body — dismemberment and body destruction are not in play here. And the seal is one-way: from the inside, the door opens freely for anyone (unless Sennakht was strong-armed and never said so).

The stairway opens into a vaulted corridor of pale stone, carved with patterns that shift at the edge of vision. Šauhahten has hung alchemical lanterns at intervals; their sickly yellow light makes everything look jaundiced. From below: the sound of fluid moving through glass, and a faint, rhythmic scratching — pen on paper.

Group check — Subterfuge D3: the party descends quietly. If most of the party succeeds, Šauhahten is mid-work when they arrive: the conversation below happens on the party’s terms, and the party acts first if (when) it comes to blows. If most fail, a homunculus spots them and scurries ahead — Šauhahten is standing, prepared, facing the entrance when they enter, and the Chimera is already at his side rather than in its alcove. The conversation still happens; he was always going to want to explain himself.

This one check replaces the whole “alert level” apparatus of a longer campaign version. It is a group check so all seven players roll something on the way in — and so Pâhâk, several hundred kilos of Ironhands, gets to be the reason the plan goes loud. Let that be funny.

SCENE 5: THE LABORATORY

Time budget: 65 minutes — roughly 15 of talk and 50 of fight. Lesson: powers and FP under pressure, and objectives beyond “kill everything.”

THE DESCENT

The laboratory is beautiful in a way that makes your skin crawl. Glassware of extraordinary precision lines the walls. A distillation array — copper, silver, and crystal — dominates the central chamber, its tubes and vessels arranged with an artisan's care. Journals are stacked neatly on a writing desk. Small waxy figures, knee-high, move among the benches on quick precise errands. Something the size of a cart horse breathes wetly in an alcove, and the stone hisses faintly where it lies.

And in a recess at the back of the room, sealed glass vessels glow with a pale, shifting light. Each holds a luminous substance that moves like something alive. Beside the recess stands a tall mirror in a silver frame, its surface too dark for the room it reflects.

These are the souls. And this is the man.

THE CONVERSATION

Šauhahten speaks before fighting. He has been waiting years for an audience capable of understanding him.

He is standing by the distillation array when you enter. Tall, even for a Mirror — the fey shimmer of an Echo plays across his features, making his expression difficult to read. He does not reach for a weapon. He does not look afraid.

“Ah,” he says, as if you are guests who have arrived slightly ahead of schedule. “I had wondered when someone would come. Please — do not touch anything. Some of these compounds are volatile, and I would hate for anyone to be hurt unnecessarily.

“I assume you are here about the disappearances. I understand why that would concern people. I would like to explain, if you will let me. What I am doing here is important — more important than you know, and certainly more important than the lives it has cost. I know how that sounds. I ask only that you hear me out before you decide.”

His argument, in brief: the cycle of death and rebirth is broken. Souls do not pass on — they linger, they suffer, they are consumed by the Fog. Prima Materia is the key to restarting the cycle. Yes, the process requires the rendering down of souls. Yes, it is terrible. But the alternative — an eternity of suffering for every mortal who dies — is worse. He has done the calculus. A few dozen lives now, to save every soul that will ever exist.

He is calm, articulate, and genuinely believes this. He is not lying and he is not performing. He is also wrong — or at least, the voice in the Fog that guides his work has its own agenda, and *he does not know that*. If the party mentions Sennakht, something crosses his face that is almost homesickness: “She taught me to finish my proofs. I am finishing one.”

Let the party argue with him — this is where seven players who have been fighting and rolling all evening get to just *talk* — but keep a hand on the clock. Ten minutes of debate is a gift; twenty is a problem. When you need the fight, he provides the exit: he asks, politely, whether they intend to destroy his work. Any honest answer starts the battle.

The moral trap: if anyone is tempted to agree with him — and with a good table, someone will be — draw their eyes to the sealed vessels. **Occultism D2:** the substance inside is not abstract distillate. Those are *people* — aware, trapped, suspended in a state of conscious dissolution. The extraction does not kill cleanly.

The moment of temptation should feel real. Complicity should not be reachable — if the party somehow sides with him anyway, Merzaghaal's scouts arrive within the hour and the session ends in a very different conversation. But that is a failure state to know about, not to plan for.

COMBAT: THE PROOF DEFENDED

Encounter composition (7 characters):

- **Šauhahten** (T1 Boss)
 - **The Chimera** (T1 Elite) — lurching from its alcove
 - 4 **Alchemical Homunculi** (T1 Minion) — snatching up vessels of something that steams
- Stat blocks are in the Appendix.

Running the fight (7 players): three enemy turns per round — Šauhahten, the Chimera, all homunculi together — plus Šauhahten's Legendary Reflex once per round after someone else's turn. Use the Reflex loudly ("as Zamazaha finishes her swing, he is simply *elsewhere*") so the players feel the boss fighting seven of them.

Šauhahten's priorities:

1. **Protect the distillation array.** He bodies the line between the party and the array; whoever moves on it eats his focus fire.
2. **Distillation Overload early and often.** He knows they will wreck the array; he spends it while he has it.
3. **Fey Displacement** to stay out of melee. He is a ranged fighter with seven opponents; he never willingly ends a turn adjacent to Ushtëng or Zamazaha.
4. **Soul Siphon** whoever has the lowest Ward, to sustain.

The Chimera guards Šauhahten's flank and punishes clumps with Sweeping Lash. Its regeneration stops at the first fire or Thermal damage — Wishanya's flamethrower or Kho Prea's Sunfire Blessing. When a player figures that out, confirm it visibly: the wounds stop closing, and the Chimera *notices*.

The homunculi screen for their maker and self-destruct gladly — remind melee characters about Alembic Burst the first time one pops.

If a character dies: this is the payoff of Scene 4. The player knows what death costs and what 5 EP buys. Give them the full ritual of it: the fall, the choice, the rise at full HP with a complete turn. Nothing in the session will teach the game's identity harder than dying in the boss fight and standing back up angry.

The victory condition is not killing Šauhahten — it is destroying the laboratory. Say this out loud when the fight starts, via Sennakht's words if needed: *the man comes back; the work is what matters*.

- **The distillation array** (central chamber): 2 AP and an **Athletics D3** (smashing), or any attack dealing 10+ damage to it. When it goes, Šauhahten loses Distillation Overload and his composure cracks: +1d on his attacks, -1d on all his resist checks, for the rest of the fight.
- **The research journals** (writing desk): 1 AP to burn or shred. If the party promised them to Sennakht, this is the promise, breaking.
- **The soul vessels** (back recess): 1 AP per vessel; there are three. Released souls dissipate with an expression that might be gratitude. Šauhahten reacts with genuine anguish — not for the people, for the material.
- **The reagent stockpile** (side chamber): 2 AP, and messy — volatile compounds detonate in a **Burst 1** of chemical fire, 6 damage, **Evasion D2** negates, centred on the stockpile.

Track destruction on a visible tally. The contract is fulfilled if the array and the stockpile are gone — the rest is conscience, promises, and loot (each destroyed target reduces the salvage; see the Loot Table). As targets fall, Šauhahten's mask goes with them:

- **0–1 destroyed:** composed, clinical, lecturing between attacks. "You do not understand what you are doing."
- **2 destroyed:** the voice rises. "You are condemning *every soul that will ever die* to an eternity in the Fog!"
- **3–4 destroyed:** grandiose rage, tactics abandoned, the nearest enemy attacked. "I am the only one! The only one who sees! And you — you *insects* —"

The Vanishing

Šauhahten does not die here. When he is reduced below 12 HP — or when the array and stockpile are gone and the fight is plainly lost — he breaks for the silvered mirror at the back of the laboratory.

He looks at the wreck of his life's work, and then at you, and the rage drains out of his face all at once, which is worse.

"Years," he says. "You have cost the world years. I hope you live long enough to understand what you did today."

He steps backward into the silver mirror as if into a doorway. The surface takes him like still water takes a stone — and then the mirror crazes from frame to frame and falls out of the world, and the laboratory is quiet.

The escape is not an encounter to win; the mirror is keyed to him and shatters behind him. If a player has a held action or a clever interdiction, let them scar him on the way out — a bolt through the shoulder as the silver closes — but he goes. Award his full XP; the party beat him in every way that was on offer tonight.

If the party somehow drops him to 0 HP before he reaches the mirror — burst damage happens — he dies mid-stride, shattering like a dropped reflection... and he is Deathless. His essence departs for a soul anchor that is very far from here. The epilogue barely changes; he simply returns angrier, later.

AFTERMATH

The seal is one-way: from the inside, the door stands open for anyone (if Sennakht never told them — because she was Imposed upon — give them one bad minute at the foot of the stairs before someone notices the threshold circle is inert from this side).

Salvage: see the Loot Table in the Appendix. In broad strokes — whatever the party did not blow up is worth money, the journals are worth promises, and the soul vessels are worth nothing but mean everything.

EPILOGUE: CONTRACT FILLED

Time budget: 10 minutes. **Lesson:** what playing on looks like.

The party returns to Keshto. Merzaghaal pays the contract — **700 f** — and listens to the full report without interrupting, which from him is high praise.

Give each character one closing beat, a sentence apiece:

- **Ushtëng:** Vazhan's halberd, carried home. The Never-Still will bury the sergeant with it, unless Ushtëng would rather keep it.
- **Mbazân:** the watch dead are named and avenged; his own patrols sleep safer for what he learned here.
- **Kho Prea:** the Clear's thinning at the western edge remains — whatever Šauhahten was doing, it was not the whole story. The Children of the Flame will want a full report.
- **Pâhâk:** the Perfectors are *very* interested in the laboratory's intact magitek. The reply to Pâhâk's report is one line: "Observe the Mortefactors. Further orders follow."
- **Wishanya:** whatever she read of the journals — or salvaged of them — is a season of study. Methodical, as suspected. Predictable, as promised.
- **Kalariyar:** the door knew them. Sennakht, if they parted on good terms, offers one quiet thread to pull: "There are other doors, night-child. Bring me a rubbing of the next one you find."
- **Zamazaha:** seven hundred feathers, split seven ways, plus salvage. The name "Zamazaha" is worth slightly more in the Black Guard's ledgers tonight than it was this morning.

And for the table:

Somewhere beyond the Weald, in the grey where the Fog thickens toward the old world, a tall figure walks with a slight new stoop, doing arithmetic. Materials. Years. Names.

Something in the Fog walks with him, patient as weather, and says — as it has always said — *keep going*.

He lives to fight another day. So, for now, does everyone else.

Open threads, for whoever runs the next session: Šauhahten is alive, educated by defeat, and guided by a patron whose nature this adventure deliberately leaves undefined — it is not what he thinks it is, and it benefits from souls being rendered down. Sennakht knows more about the Deep Court doors than she has said. The journals, if they survived, are now somebody's problem. And the Never-Still remember who fulfilled the contract.

APPENDIX

BESTIARY

All creatures in the adventure, in order of appearance.

Soulless Husk

The reanimated bodies of Šauhahten's victims, stripped of their souls and filled with just enough residual Fog energy to move. They are slow, relentless, and unsettling. They do not speak, do not retreat, and do not respond to pain. The six at the dump site wear peacekeeper colors.

SOULLESS HUSK

T1 MINION

UNDEAD MINDLESS

HP 10 | **Arm** 5 | **Wrd** 3 | **Eva** 2 | **AP** 3 | **Speed** 2

Immunities: Frightened, Dominated

Martial 5 **Stamina** 4 **Grit** 3

ACTIONS

⚔ **Slam** (2 AP)

Melee, Martial vs Evasion, single target

Damage: 3+1D8

On hit: Target is Grabbed (save ends). While Grabbed, the Husk does not need to spend AP to maintain the grab.

XP 7

Fog-Touched Beast

A predator warped by prolonged Fog exposure, drawn to areas of residual supernatural energy. Aggressive but not suicidal — a beast below half HP flees.

FOG-TOUCHED BEAST

T1 STANDARD

BEAST FOG-TOUCHED

HP 22 | **Arm** 5 | **Wrd** 4 | **Eva** 2 | **AP** 4 | **Speed** 4

Martial 6 **Stamina** 5 **Grit** 4

ACTIONS

⚔ **Bite** (2 AP)

Melee, Martial vs Evasion, single target

Damage: 4+1D8

⚔ **Pounce** (2 AP)

Move up to Speed, then Melee, Martial vs Evasion, single target

Damage: 4+1D8

On hit: Target is Exposed (save ends).

XP 15

Vazhan, Hollow Revenant

Sergeant of the Never-Still watch, Ushtâng's friend, and Šauhahten's one failed extraction: a fragment of soul remained, and the Fog wove the residue of the other victims around it. He holds the cave mouth like the watchman he was, and screams with voices that are not his own.

VAZHAN, HOLLOW REVENANT

T1 ELITE

UNDEAD FOG-TOUCHED PEACEKEEPER

HP 32 | Arm 5 | Wrd 6 | Eva 2 | AP 4 | Speed 3

Immunities: Frightened, Dominated

Martial 6 Potential 6 Stamina 5 Grit 6

TRAITS

What Remains: Once per round, a character may spend 1 AP to call Vazhan by name. Until the end of the round, Vazhan attacks that character with -1d. A character who knew Vazhan in life needs no check; anyone else must succeed on an **Influence D3** as part of the action.

ACTIONS

⚔ Halberd of the Watch (2 AP)

Melee (reach 2), Martial vs Evasion, single target

Damage: 5+1D8

He still fights with the drill-ground precision of a watch sergeant. The residue does not remember why.

🌀 Wail of the Taken (3 AP)

Burst 2 centred on self; each creature in the area resists with Grit D3

Damage: 4 psychic on a failed resist, and the target is Dazed until the end of its next turn. On a success, no damage.

The voices of every soul Šauhahten has taken scream through him at once.

👁 Grasp of Residue (2 AP)

Ranged 6, Potential vs Ward, single target

Damage: 4+1D6 psychic

On hit: Target is Slowed (save ends). Pale, half-formed hands clutch at the target from the Fog.

XP 30

The Chimera

The living byproduct of the Prima Materia process — fused tissue grown around a cauldron-heart, kept because destroying it would waste the material. Its wounds close on their own until fire teaches them not to.

THE CHIMERA

T1 ELITE

Size 2 Construct

CONSTRUCT ALCHEMICAL SIZE 2

HP 45 | Arm 6 | Wrd 5 | Eva 2 | AP 4 | Speed 4

Immunities: Frightened, Dominated, Poisoned

Martial 7 Stamina 6 Grit 5

TRAITS

Regeneration: The Chimera recovers 3 HP at the start of each of its turns. This regeneration ceases for the rest of the scene the first time the Chimera takes fire or Thermal damage.

ACTIONS

⚔ Rending Bite (2 AP)

Melee, Martial vs Evasion, single target

Damage: 6+1D10

⚔ Lurching Charge (3 AP)

Move up to Speed, then Melee, Martial vs Evasion, single target, +1d to hit

Damage: 6+1D10

On hit: Target is knocked Prone.

🌀 Sweeping Lash (2 AP)

Melee, Martial vs Evasion, all enemies within 2 squares

Damage: 4+1D8

XP 30

Alchemical Homunculus

Šauhahten's knee-high laboratory assistants, animated by a droplet of soul residue each. In peacetime they stir, fetch, and take notes. In wartime they are ammunition.

ALCHEMICAL HOMUNCULUS

T1 MINION

Size 0 Construct

CONSTRUCT ALCHEMICAL SIZE 0

HP 8 | Arm 4 | Wrd 4 | Eva 3 | AP 3 | Speed 4

Immunities: Frightened, Dominated, Poisoned

Martial 4 Stamina 3 Grit 3

TRAITS

Alembic Burst: When the Homunculus is destroyed, its reagent core shatters — Burst 1 centred on it, 3 chemical damage, **Evasion D2** negates.

ACTIONS

→ **Caustic Alembic** (2 AP)

Melee or Ranged 5, Martial vs Evasion, single target

Damage: 3+1D6 chemical

It swings, or throws, a stoppered vessel of something that steams where it splashes.

XP 7

Šauhahten, the Mad Alchemist

Mirror, ex-Mortefactor, Deathless. Calm, articulate, and utterly certain that his murders are arithmetic. He fights to defend the work, not to kill — and he does not intend to die here.

ŠAUHAHTEN, THE MAD ALCHEMIST

T1 BOSS

DEATHLESS MIRROR HUMANOID

HP 55 | FP 30 | Arm 6 | Wrd 5 | Eva 3 | AP 5 | Speed 3

Immunities: Dominated

Arcane 7 Martial 5 Potential 6 Stamina 5 Grit 5

TRAITS

Legendary Reflex: Once per round, after another creature ends its turn, Šauhahten may move up to 3 squares or make an Alchemical Bolt attack. This costs no AP.

Desperate Fury: While below half HP, Šauhahten gains +1d on all attack rolls and his Evasion is reduced by 1 (to 2).

The Vanishing: Šauhahten does not intend to die here. When reduced below 12 HP — or when his laboratory is lost and the fight with it — he escapes through the silvered mirror at the back of the laboratory (see *The Vanishing* in Scene 5). Award full XP.

ACTIONS

→ **Alchemical Bolt** (2 AP)

Ranged 10, Arcane vs Evasion, single target

Damage: 5+1D8

Šauhahten hurls a volatile alchemical compound that detonates on impact.

⌚ **Soul Siphon** (3 AP)

Ranged 8, Arcane vs Ward, single target

Damage: 6+1D12

On hit: Šauhahten heals HP equal to half the damage dealt.

A tendril of pale light connects Šauhahten to the target, drawing vitality from them. Mortefactor technique.

↪ **Fey Displacement** (1 AP)

Trigger: Šauhahten is hit by an attack.

Šauhahten teleports up to 3 squares. Once per round.

His Mirror nature allows him to step briefly between reflections.

⌚ **Distillation Overload** (3 AP)

Burst 2 within 8, Arcane vs Evasion

Damage: 10+2D8

Šauhahten destabilizes one of his alchemical apparatuses, causing it to violently discharge. This ability is only available while the distillation array in the laboratory is intact. Each use visibly damages the equipment.

XP 60

SKILL CHECK REFERENCE

SKILL CHECKS BY SCENE

Scene	Skill	DC	Result
1 — Keshto	Investigate	2	Disappearance timeline and northeast pattern
1 — Keshto	Influence	3	Reeve opens up about the toll on the community
1 — Keshto	Influence	2	Dashek talks; detailed directions (tracking bonus)
1 — Keshto	Awareness	3	Dashek is carrying guilt, not information
1 — Keshto	Investigate	3	Find lbbeh, who remembers the Mirror customer
1 — Tracking	Awareness	3	Read the terrain (group check stretch)
1 — Tracking	Investigate	3	Reason out the disposal logic (group check stretch)
1 — Tracking	Stamina	4	Push through terrain and Fog-headache (stretch)
2 — Dump Site	Awareness	3	Spot the tarp moving; not surprised by the husks
2 — Dump Site	Athletics	2	Scramble up to the north ridgeline in 1 square
2 — Cave	Occultism	3	Souls extracted deliberately — not a predator
2 — Cave	Medicine/Alchemy	4	Surgical method; desiccation is a side effect

2 — Cave	Investigate	3	Months of use; iterated circles; lone perpetrator
2 — Cave	Ritual/Occultism	3/4	Not necromancy — scholarly soul-distillation
3 — Sennakht	Influence	3	Appeal to the victims; she opens up
3 — Sennakht	Occultism	3	Speak her language; treated as a colleague
3 — Sennakht	Impose	4	She talks — flatly, omitting the one-way door
4 — Threshold	Occultism	2	Read the inscription: give the door your death
4 — Descent	Subterfuge	3	Group check: arrive unannounced, act first
5 — Laboratory	Occultism	2	The soul vessels hold aware, suffering people
5 — Laboratory	Athletics	3	Smash the distillation array (2 AP)

LOOT TABLE

Values are per party, not per character.

LOOT BY LOCATION

Location	Item	Value	Notes
Dump Site	Personal effects of victims	50 f	Coins, trinkets, gear — returning them to Keshto is worth more goodwill than feathers
Cave	Crude reagents and glassware	100 f	Extraction byproducts, salvageable
Laboratory	Alchemical equipment	400 f	Destroyed if the distillation array is smashed
Laboratory	Refined reagents	200 f	Destroyed if the stockpile is detonated
Laboratory	Research journals	300 f	Promised to Sennakht? Destroyed? The party chooses

Laboratory	Soul vessels (intact)	—	No sale value. Releasing the souls is its own reward
Laboratory	Šauhahten's personal effects	100 f	Mirror-crafted tools, cipher notes
Maximum total		1150 f	Everything intact — which means the contract's primary targets survived
Typical total		300–600 f	Array and stockpile destroyed per the mission

XP SUMMARY

XP PER CHARACTER

Source	XP	Notes
Soulless Husks (×6)	42	Scene 2, 7 each
Fog-Touched Beasts (×2)	30	Scene 2, 15 each
Vazhan, Hollow Revenant	30	Scene 2 mini-boss
The Chimera	30	Scene 5
Alchemical Homunculi (×4)	28	Scene 5, 7 each
Šauhahten	60	Scene 5 — awarded in full when he flees
Mission: fulfil the contract	100	Array and stockpile destroyed
Loot XP	30–60	1 XP per 10 f recovered
Total	350–380	Per character

CLUE SAFETY NET

The adventure needs the party to learn three things. None of them can be lost to bad dice:

1. **Something is extracting souls, northeast.** Dashek's directions are given freely; the dump site delivers the rest on sight.

2. **The method belongs to a scholarly order.**

The notebook page behind the distillation rig is found without a check; Merzaghaal makes the Mortefactor connection and points to Sennakht.

3. **The lair is under the shrine, and the door takes a death.**

Sennakht provides both once persuaded — and if the party never wins her over, Merzaghaal's faction channels produce the name and the place overnight, leaving only the door's secret to be learned the hard way at the threshold (Kalariyar feels it; the inscription spells it out at **Occultism D2**).

OPEN THREADS

Deliberately unresolved, for whoever runs the next session:

Šauhahten Will Return

He escaped with his knowledge and his conviction intact and his life's work in ashes. He will start over — somewhere else, with better security, and with a list of names. Whether he seeks the party out or simply resumes elsewhere sets the tone of the next arc.

The Patron in the Fog

Šauhahten was guided by a voice in the Fog — an intelligence that offered knowledge and encouragement. It is not what he thinks it is. It benefits from souls being rendered down. Beyond that, the GM decides: a dead god's echo, a Faerie parasite, a Fog-born intelligence, or something else entirely.

Sennakht and the Doors

She knows more about the Deep Court seals than she said, and she asked Kalariyar to bring her rubbings of other doors. A retired Lector with two hundred years of guilt makes an excellent patron — or an excellent tragedy.

The Research

If the journals survived, someone now holds detailed notes on Prima Materia extraction — Sennakht, the Order, or the party's packs. If they burned, the knowledge lives only in Šauhahten's memory. Either way, the Perfectors have told Pâhâk to keep watching.